



ILLUSTRATION BY **RAJ VERMA**

merce giants. Instead of a centralised marketplace, ONDC allows any seller, buyer, and logistics provider to transact seamlessly. This creates a level-playing field for small businesses, allowing them to reach customers without having to commit to expensive hyperscaler platforms. The same principle is being applied to energy, where decentralised power grids will allow homes with rooftop solar panels and EV batteries to buy and sell power seamlessly.

Of course, challenges remain. The biggest among them is data privacy and security. While India has an enormous digital footprint that could be leveraged for AI training, care must be taken in releasing datasets for training AI models to protect privacy. Regulatory frameworks

around AI, financial tokenisation, and data ownership will need to keep pace with innovation. The second challenge is ensuring that Digital Bharat is truly inclusive. While urban centres have benefited tremendously from the India Stack, rural India has been left behind. Going forward, government and the private sector must focus on infrastructure expansion, digital literacy programmes, and localised AI solutions tailored for non-English speakers.

The most pressing concern is employment. As AI automates various tasks, India must proactively think about how it can create AI-proof jobs. The answer lies not in resisting automation but in designing AI systems that augment human capability rather than replace it. Agriculture,

healthcare, and education can all benefit from AI-driven insights while still retaining the need for human expertise. If we do this right, AI will be a force for job creation rather than disruption.

Looking ahead, the global potential of India's DPI stack is enormous. The 50-in-5 initiative aims to bring India's digital public infrastructure to 50 countries in five years. Aadhaar-inspired iden-

Unlike the expensive, compute-heavy models built in the West, India is taking a more frugal approach

tity systems are already being deployed in several nations through the MOSIP open-source project. NPCI is actively engaging with other countries to expand UPI's footprint. The next phase will see Indian fintech companies, telecom providers, and AI start-ups scaling their solutions globally, particularly in emerging markets where cost-effective, high-scale digital infrastructure is desperately needed.

Digital Bharat will be built on creative recombination of the building blocks of Aadhaar, UPI, ONDC, and AI. With careful governance, India has the potential to be a digital powerhouse for all citizens, as well as a beacon of innovation for the world. **BT**

Views are personal